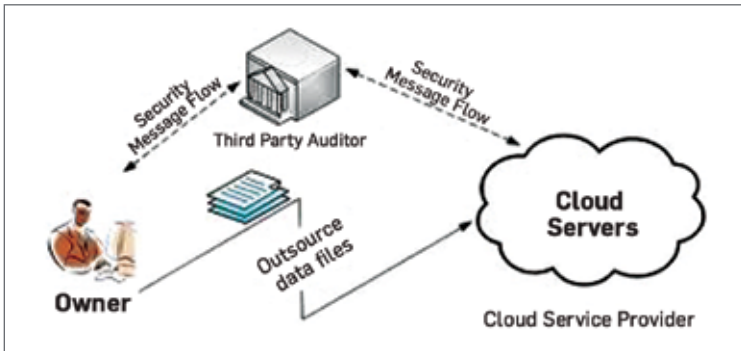




cloud storage services enable the data uploaded by users to be stored on an off-site storage system maintained by a third party server. For instance, when you upload data onto your Google Drive account, what is happening behind the screens is that the packet of information that you send is being routed to whichever server your user account's files are on, which usually isn't the web server that serves you Google Drive's pages. The Google Drive server (facilitator) you are connected to is acting as a go-between your PC and the storage system, and merely graphically displaying what you have stored, and sending commands to modify as you make changes in the interface.

Cloud storage facilitators depend on hundreds of servers, running round the clock and picking up the slack if one of them fails or falls off the network. Knowing all too well that computers too need maintenance and an occasional cool off, any information you send to the cloud is stored on several systems. Redundancy of systems is absolutely necessary if the facilities intend on providing continuous uptime.

In addition to multiple servers carrying the same data, cloud storage facilities also ensure that the servers that store information use different power supplies, and often, ensure that identical information is never stored on another server in the same datacentre. This arrangement ensures that clients still have access to their information in the event of a power failure, or even an entire datacentre being disabled.

Cloud Storage facilitators have extended their interface to provide the same services on mobile devices, with a version for each operating system. You can now access data stored on the cloud on the go, making you and your smartphone even smarter. Just as any portfolio manager would advise you not to put too many eggs in one basket, diversify your data storage as well.